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FEATURING

THE ASSISTANT SELF

An Amazing Short Novel

By F. L. WALLACE

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE VIDIOD ***

Transcribed from Fantastic Universe, March 1956 (Vol. 5, No. 2.).

The Vidiot

by **Ib Melchior**

To the best of our knowledge the Metropolitan Opera stage has never before cast its mantle of magic over the science fiction landscape. But with the coming of Ib Melchior to our pages with his first fantasy story its legendary spell has been widened. For Mr. Melchior is the son of a singer so famous that to mention his name would be redundant. Quite as important, Ib Melchior is a motion picture producer as well as a writer, with several TV shows behind him, including the Perry Como Show on CBS. Much of his background and experience as a producer-director is mirrored forth in this most exciting yarn.

There are a good many startling surprises in TV camera work. But if the universe reels—will an eager lad get a second chance?

“Don Hartley!” The little blonde secretary’s eyes opened wide with curiosity as she repeated his name. *She knows, then*, thought Don.

“Just—just a minute,” she said. She picked up the phone and pressed the inter-office button. “Mr. Don Hartley to see you, sir,” she announced. Then after a pause, “Yes, sir.”

She replaced the receiver, and turned back to Don. “Won’t you please have a seat, Mr. Hartley. He’ll see you in a moment.”

Don sat uncomfortably on the edge of one of the heavy, leather-upholstered chairs. He looked around the beautifully appointed ante-office. The little secretary was trying in vain to be inconspicuous in her curiosity about him. He shifted self-consciously on the chair.

Was he in the right place? Had he really made the right decision? It was a damned difficult thing to figure out!

For the umpteenth time he let his mind wander back twenty-four hours—a measly twenty-four hours—when....

George Kenmore flipped the talk-back key: “Okay, everybody—wrap it up. That’s it for now. Be back here ready to go from the top in exactly one hour and a half.”

He turned to the technical director, a large, comfortable man who sat worrying a dead cigar on his left.

“And, Steve,” he warned, “don’t kill the cameras. Just cap them up so we don’t burn in. You and the boys be back here in one hour. I’ve got a little problem I want to fool around with. That duplicator effect on Ganymede.”

He leaned across the control desk toward the row of monitors in front of him on the lower level of the video control room, addressing himself to the top of a crew cut.

“And, Don,” he added, “be sure we have horizontal reverse scanning on Camera One. And I want to use the whipe—and also I want you to switch the matting amplifier into the circuit.”

The video technician looked up over his shoulder. “Okay, George. You know me. A director’s wish is my command! But they sure handed you a tough one this time.”

“What do you expect? After all we’re doing a space opera—on *live* TV. There are bound to be technical difficulties. As long as they don’t ask me for a close-up with the feet in we’ll lick any problem they can dream up. Right?”

“Right!” echoed Don brightly. “Anything the movie boys can do with process shooting and laboratory tricks we can do right here in the studio—and better. I’m with *you*!”

George picked up his earphones from the desk and spoke into the tiny mike. “Bill! Bill Sanders! Are you still on cans?”

Out on the studio floor one of the men waved his arm. George saw him through the double glass pane and continued: “Good! Tell the boys to let in the big black in two—in front of the spaceship set. And get the fog machine set. I’m going to use a half hour of fax rehearsal time when we get back for some experimenting. Has the dry ice arrived yet?”

On the floor Bill waved “yes.”

“Okay.”

“Tell me, George,” the T.D. asked. “What exactly is the effect you want in that Ganymede scene?”

George picked up a paper clip and absent-mindedly began twisting it around his pencil in a tight spiral. It was a silly habit of his, but an innocuous one.

“It’s like this,” he began to explain. “We’re on Ganymede—that’s one of Jupiter’s moons. The ‘Planeteer’ has landed and is walking around on the satellite in his space suit. We’ll play the whole thing in front of the black drop and put in electronic stars.”

He leaned over the desk. “Can do, Don?”

“Can do!”

“Fine! Now—the floor will be covered with dry ice fog. It’s supposed to be ammonia vapors or some such guck. So far so good.”

He rolled his little paper clip spiral off his pencil and started on another one.

“The ‘Planeteer’ is all alone, see? But suddenly another spacesuited figure joins him. It turns out to be *he himself*—and duplicated! And if that’s not enough, a third copy joins them—all three of them *he himself*. He’s supposed to look at himself, talk to himself, and walk in front of himself. We can’t use doubles because of those transparent space helmets. And what’s more, the three triplicated ‘Planeteers’ are supposed to make the exact same movements at the exact same time. The whole thing’s supposed to be some sort of hallucination.”

He stood up. “And speaking about hallucinations—I’m so hungry *I’m* going to get them if I don’t get something to eat. Coming, Steve?”

“Fine,” said the T.D.

The director leaned across the desk again. “And how about our *vidiot*? You want to join us, Don?” he asked.

Don cringed mentally at the nickname. Even though he knew it was only a good-natured rib at the video technicians he always winced at the term “vidiot.”

But he managed to sound unconcerned when he answered: “Guess not, George. I’m not hungry. Besides I’ve got a heavy date after the show. I’ll just stick around here.”

“See you later, then,” the director said as he and his T.D. left the control room. On the studio floor Bill, the floor manager, let a last look of inspection sweep the stage. Then he too walked out.

Studio 52 was deserted—except for Don Hartley.

Fine! That would give him a chance. He was pretty sure he knew what the director had in mind, and how he would solve his problem of triplication. If he could have everything set up when George returned the director was bound to send a note of commendation to Barnes, the big brass in the front office. Don was ambitious. He had his eye on the T.D. chair, even on that of the director himself. And who could know? Everything was possible.

Now. He’d use three cameras. Take the first picture of the “Planeteer” on Camera III—normal scanning. Then he’d split the screen vertically on the whipe amplifier, putting the image from Camera III on the right half of the

screen. Then on Camera I he'd take another picture of the "Planeteer" and reverse the scanning horizontally so that right became left, and vice versa.

Then he'd put the image from Camera I on the left half of the screen, and he'd have two identical "Planeteers" looking at each other. That would work out all right. Now. On Camera II he'd take yet another picture of the "Planeteer," and using the matting amplifier with primary picture on Camera II he could put the third "Planeteer" in front of the two others. It would work. He'd have to try it out.

Don walked out on the stage. From the prop room he got a space suit in a light blue color and propped it up on the Test Pattern stand in front of the black backdrop. That would be the "Planeteer." Next he lined up his two pedestal cameras and swung in the huge boom camera so that all three had a full figure shot of the space suit.

He returned to the control room and completed his intricate hookup. It worked. One space suit "Planeteer" had become three!

He reached up behind him to punch up his montage picture on the studio monitor so he could watch it out on the floor while he moved around in front of the cameras. As he swept his arm across the desk to the master switchboard there was a tiny scratching sound. This became the sound of an object rolling—and then falling off the desk.

There was a sharp crack and an acrid puff of smoke as one of George's little paper clip spirals fell down into the exposed mass of tubes and wires of the matting amplifier.

For a split second Don's world stood still. His first reaction was a quick glance at the line monitor. The picture was still there, but—something had happened to it. The matting amplifier worked by "punching" a hole in the image taken by one camera the exact shape of the image taken by a second camera and putting this second image into the hole.

The hole was there all right. It was the exact shape of the propped-up space suit. But it was a hole without an image. It was a hole of utter jet black.

Don knew he ought to kill his B Plus before any more damage was done, but there was something about the total blackness of that hole in the picture on the monitor tube which fascinated him. It simply wasn't possible to get such a perfect black, even if you dug for it. He began cautiously to turn the brightness control. Slowly the blackness became lighter.

All of a sudden an image appeared in the hole! Don worked the contrast control. The picture came swiftly into focus. It was *not* the image of the space suit as it should have been. Through the hole shaped like the space suit Don was looking into the interior of a spaceship!

At once Don's mind supplied an answer. Something had happened to his hookup when that metal spiral had fallen into the matting amplifier and fused certain connections! Now he was actually able to pick up images from an extra-terrestrial spaceship! He must be excused, however. He had worked a long time on that TV space opera. And it wasn't long before he realized that what he was actually seeing in the hole was merely the spaceship set built for "The Planeteers." He was about to kill his power when it struck him like a 1000-volt camera shock. How could he *see* the spaceship set? It was *behind* the big black backdrop!

He studied the image on the monitor intently. That was it, all right. No mistake about it. He was looking right through the heavy, black duvetyne backdrop with Camera II. Or—He suddenly had a thought.

Don ran out into the studio. Bill usually kept a piece of chalk for floor markings near his cans. There! He went over Camera I. Carefully he drew on the floor a straight line at a 90-degree angle to the lens from the camera over to the black drop. Then he went to Camera II and did the same. The lines did not converge in front of the drop.

He ran behind the black, lifted up the bottom to orientate himself and continued the lines on the other side. They crossed each other right smack in the middle of the spaceship set.

There could only be one answer. But Don had to be sure.

He went back to Camera II and carefully swung it a little to the right. Now the two imaginary lines would cross about 100 feet further out.

He ran back to the control room. And there—in the spacesuit-shaped hole in the monitor image he watched the traffic on the street outside the studio

roar silently by! He was seeing through the backdrop, through the scenery stored at the rear of the studio, through the wall itself, and into the street. Wherever the lines from the two cameras would cross—*he saw!* He estimated the focal depth of the picture to be about ten feet on either side of the actual crossing point of the vitally important imaginary lines.

He sat back. He was trembling a little. His hands felt clammy. But he soon got hold of himself. He looked at the control room clock. One thirty-three. The guys would be back in about twenty minutes. He had to hurry. He killed the power, switched on his work lamp, and peered into the innards of the fused, mutilated matting amplifier. From the storing case he hauled out the complete circuit blueprint, and set to work.

The next fifteen minutes were spent in sketching in new connections and bridges and crossing out old ones on the drawings. Then Don carefully fished out the paper clip spiral and deliberately dropped the heavy work light into the amplifier. There was the sharp noise of splintering tubes. Stuffing the corrected circuit blueprints in his pocket Don hurriedly left the studio minutes before the crew returned to continue their rehearsal for “The Planeteers.”

Don walked quickly through the mid-day crowd towards the park. Barnes would have his hide—first for wrecking the matting amplifier and secondly for walking out on the rehearsal. But he desperately needed time to think. So what if he was fired! It was a *big* thing he’d come across.

He had immediately recognized the tremendous possibilities of his accidental discovery. It had been simple for him to analyze the circuit changes produced by the paper clip spiral and to realize that it would literally be child’s play to construct a single camera which could be focused on any given area and pick up an image regardless of whatever obstacles might lay between, unknown to anyone in the area! With this camera he could reach in anywhere with an invisible, all-seeing eye. And he was the only one who had this secret. Reflexively he touched the pocket which held his notes.

He definitely did not want to give this discovery to the network. He still remembered and resented that objectionable clause in his employment contract: *I will assign to you irrevocably any and all rights I may have or*

get to all “inventions” made by me alone or with others, whether during or outside of my regular working hours.

Like hell he would! This was one thing that number one boy wasn't giving away. There was a mint to be made—and Donny boy was going to make it!

It was a warm, sunny day. Don hunted up a quiet corner in the park and relaxed on the grass. He had some tall thinking to do.

Let's face it. He had a pure uranium mine on his hands. Just imagine what could be done with it! Entertainment could be plucked right out of the theaters, sports arenas, ball parks, anywhere. News events could be covered immediately and wherever they might occur by a spin of a dial. Even “Person to Person” wouldn't need all that cumbersome equipment! The military could watch war games, attacks, any development, in safety. Why, almost anyone could explore, maybe even discover rich mineral deposits with his new, penetrating TV camera! You could observe the bottom of an ocean and the heart of a mountain. Yes, sir! He would revolutionize TV pick-up and transmission. Maybe even the secrets of space itself—

He felt dizzy. There was no end to the possibilities. And he was sitting on top of the gizmo that would do it! The Hartley Penetelecam! Or simpler still: *The Hartleycam!*

He'd let someone like General Electric handle it. Possibly RCA. And the right would be his. He'd be a Croesus. Rich as Rothchild. Another Rockefeller! He'd buy up part of this park and put up Hartley Center. And he'd have his office on the entire penthouse floor. The inventor and controller of the Hartleycam! It would be a closely-guarded secret. Like the government's Norden Bomb Sight. Or the H-bomb. The Norden Bomb Sight—the H-bomb—the Hartleycam—the Hartleycam—

“Mr. Hartley! The president will see you now.”

A big man. Round owlsh eyes behind thin steel-framed spectacles. Did he wear a toupee?

“Sir, when I signed contracts with your corporation to develop and exploit the Hartleycam—”

“Say no more, my boy! I'm with *you!* But it is beyond my control. It has been ever since. Certain government factors have taken over, you know.

There is nothing either of us can do. It was too big—too big!”

Of course the president didn’t wear a toupee. He was bald.

It showed when he bowed. But not to Don. He was not there. He bowed to the *Hartleycam*—the *Hartleycam*—

“Mr. Hartley! The president will see you now.”

A pompous man. A man accustomed to giving orders and having them obeyed. But not recently?

“Sir! As publisher and president of the leading metropolitan newspaper—”

“Sshhh, young man! I know who you are. Don’t let too many others find out! Why did you let your spy camera get into the wrong hands? Don’t you know it is the unscrupulous, the ruthless who grab power whenever they can? What happens when that power is unconquerable???”

“But I—”

“You gave them the power to penetrate into all places. No more privacy! No more privacy—no more successful opposition to ruthless power.”

“Your paper—can’t you—”

“The freedom of the press? It is dead. Like all other freedoms—completely dead. You must conform, or else—”

They burst in unannounced. They were grim, and tall, and strong. They had black uniforms with a large silver H on the chest. H?

“I’ve been expecting you,” said the pompous publisher resignedly. “I am ready!”

“And him?” growled one of Them tossing His head at Don.

“He is only Hartley!”

They shrugged—and left....

The city was not the city. The people were not the people. There were no smiles, no joy. There were only flesh-and-blood robots with furtive eyes

and haunted looks.

And It was everywhere. Watching! He could feel it. Not the deepest dungeon nor the farthest corner was safe. It was all over him. Like a sticky, hot, unbearable beam, stabbing at his closed eyes, burning his weary brain.

Don sat up with a start. The glaring sun stood overhead. What a fool he'd been to doze off in the sun like that. He'd probably gotten himself a nice burn. No wonder he'd had a nightmare.

He gathered himself up and began walking through the park. He felt sweaty and tired—and disturbed. And he still had to make up his mind. Where to go?

The Network?

Industrial Exploitation?

The Government?

And that had been twenty-four hours earlier.

A buzzer sounded on the little secretary's desk. She was kind of cute at that—for all of her curiosity.

"You may go in now, Mr. Hartley, she announced pleasantly."

He walked towards the door. There was a black sign with white letters: V. P. GENL. ENGINEERING W. BARNES.

He entered.

"Hello, Don," said Barnes seriously, "sit down."

Don leaned back in his chair and lit a cigarette.

"Now—what's it all about?"

He had to say it fast, or he might not say it at all.

"I guess I lost my head." He nearly tripped over the words. "I was hooking up the matting amplifier for Mr. Kenmore on the 'Planeteer' show—and I dropped the worklight into it. I thought the whole thing had blown up. I got scared, and—and I just ran out of there. I don't know what came over me. I have no excuse."

He stopped. It was done. There could be no turning back.

Barnes looked at him for a moment. Then his stern face softened.

“Look, Don,” he said kindly. “We all have accidents. But we can’t afford to panic after every one. Still, it took courage to come here and face up to your mistake like this. I’m going to give you another chance.”

He got up and put his hand on Don’s shoulder. “Just don’t lose your head again,” he smiled. “And, Don, we’ll take you off ‘The Planeteers’ for a while. I guess they can get along with another vidiot!”

He slapped Don on the back good-naturedly. In the boy’s inside coat pocket a bunch of papers crackled softly. A bunch of papers which held the answer to an electronic device the boy had decided was too big. The world was not ready for the *Hartleycam*. Not yet.

Not quite yet.

Transcriber's Note:

This etext was produced from Fantastic Universe, March 1956 (Vol. 5, No. 2.). Extensive research did not uncover any evidence that the U.S. copyright on this publication was renewed.

Obvious errors have been silently corrected in this version.

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